

DECLARATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL SUMMIT ON THE DOCTRINE OF DISCOVERY AND ITS CONSEQUENCES FOR INDIGENOUS PEOPLES

1. The leaders of the Indigenous Peoples of Latin America and the Caribbean, guided by the principle and right of self-determination, have convened ourselves in Mexico City from May 18 to 22, 2026, to examine the situation regarding the application of the Doctrine of Discovery and its consequences for Indigenous Peoples and their rights. We do so bearing in mind that the application of said doctrine is intrinsically linked to the past, present, and future of Indigenous Peoples.
2. The application of the Doctrine of Discovery by European colonial systems and nation-states against Indigenous Peoples constituted a Crime Against Humanity, consisting of the dispossession of land and resources; the crime of genocide – a holocaust that remains subject to complete impunity; slavery; massive physical and psychological torture; forced displacement; the violation of tangible and intangible rights; the nullification of the right to self-determination; the destruction of civilizations and their material and non-material culture; the imposition of languages; and the denial of spirituality, among other inhumane acts contrary to human rights. All these acts mentioned in connection with the application of the Doctrine of Discovery were carried out based on the premise of illegitimate superiority. By their very nature, all these acts constitute a Crime Against Humanity and represent open wounds for the Indigenous Peoples of the Continent.
3. The Vatican bears intellectual and material responsibility for the adoption of the Papal Bulls and for the implementation of the Doctrine of Discovery, as it endorsed each and every one of the aforementioned acts. In this regard, Indigenous Peoples' organizations have repeatedly urged the Vatican to assume its institutional responsibility by formally rescinding the Doctrine of Discovery – given its illegitimate nature, its contravention of the law, and its conflict with the Christian faith itself. Concurrently with the foregoing, in 2023, Pope Francis acknowledged that the Doctrine of Discovery was unjust and, on a specific occasion, offered an apology – a highly significant gesture, yet one that remains insufficient with respect to truth, justice, and reparation for the harm inflicted.
4. The Spanish Monarchy, the governments of Spain and Portugal, and their entire colonial institutional apparatus – including the Council of the Indies and other bodies – bear direct responsibility for the application of the Doctrine of Discovery

and for all the acts enumerated in Point 2 of this Declaration. Furthermore, they enriched themselves economically through resources expropriated from Indigenous Peoples, thereby precipitating their economic impoverishment – a condition that persists to this day in the relationship between these peoples and the national states.

5. The vast majority of Latin American and Caribbean national states were established upon – and have continued to apply – the Doctrine of Discovery. This doctrine entailed the usurpation of territory; the violation of rights; the imposition of jurisdiction; economic impoverishment; and, in certain instances, the perpetration of the crime of genocide, among other forms of abuse. These acts constitute the root causes of the tensions and controversies currently characterizing the relationships between national states and Indigenous Peoples.
6. We attach significant value to the fact that, over the last decade, the Government of Mexico – and, in particular, the President of Mexico, Ms. Claudia Sheinbaum Pardo – has highlighted the culture, history, and rights of Mexico's Indigenous Peoples, thereby engaging the Government of Spain and King of Spain, Felipe VI, who have acknowledged the injustice inherent in the colonial relationship, moving beyond the narrative of the “Encounter of Two Worlds” that they upheld for centuries.
7. We acknowledge that some Heads of State in Latin America and the Caribbean have offered apologies to Indigenous Peoples; however, this remains insufficient until the historical facts have been fully clarified and the harm inflicted upon Indigenous Peoples has been redressed.
8. We reiterate the call that Indigenous Peoples' Organizations have directed to the Vatican over the past four decades regarding the revocation of the Doctrine of Discovery and its consequences, considering it to be antithetical to respect for human rights, peace, and a harmonious coexistence between Indigenous and non-Indigenous Peoples.
9. We call upon the Spanish Crown to assume responsibility for all consequences stemming from human rights violations committed during the colonial era – from 1492 onward – in the implementation of the policies derived from the Doctrine of Discovery.

10. We view positively the fact that Indigenous leaders – both men and women – participated actively in the normative process of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples, and that emerging international law has re-established and restored the right to self-determination in Articles 3 and 28 – rights that had been nullified through the material application of the Doctrine of Discovery. We hope that the Vatican, the Governments of Spain and Portugal, and the Spanish Monarchy – in the person of King Felipe VI – will follow this valuable example embodied in emerging Indigenous International Law.
11. The colonial relationship with Indigenous Peoples requires a Historical Clarification of the facts; it requires a standard of truth. This is particularly necessary given that a unilateral version of history and law has been imposed upon the Continent and its Indigenous Peoples. This situation has been brought into sharp relief by the statements made by the President of the Community of Madrid, Ms. Isabel Díaz Ayuso. During her visit to Mexico, she engaged in an apologia for institutional, military, and colonial violence, issuing capricious and deliberate statements that run counter to the possibility of acceptable coexistence between Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples – and contrary to the imperative need to build a firm and lasting peace founded upon the Clarification of Facts, justice, and reparation for the harm inflicted upon Indigenous Peoples.
12. We, Indigenous Peoples, reaffirm our inalienable and imprescriptible rights over our territories and their resources, as well as over the biodiversity and ecosystems contained therein – all of which have been adversely affected by the principles of occupation inherent in the Doctrine of Discovery, and by the implementation of policies that cause considerable damage to our territories and their resources.

**ACTION PLAN REGARDING THE DOCTRINE OF DISCOVERY AND INDIGENOUS
DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS, TO ESTABLISH A MULTILATERAL DIALOGUE, CLARIFY THE
FACTS, AND REPAIR THE HARM CAUSED TO INDIGENOUS PEOPLES.**

The Action Plan on the Doctrine of Discovery aims to guide the actions of Indigenous leaders – both men and women – within the aforementioned mandate, in order to promote the urgent need to establish a multilateral dialogue among the parties involved, interested in, and affected by the application of the Doctrine of Discovery:

1. To establish a multilateral dialogue with the involved States that bear responsibility – dating back to its genesis – for the application of the Doctrine of Discovery. These include: The Spanish Crown, currently represented by King Felipe VI; the Government of Spain, represented by current Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez; the Vatican, represented by Pope Leo XIV; the Government of Portugal; and the Latin American and Caribbean States, which were constituted upon the basis of the Doctrine of Discovery and which continue to adversely affect Indigenous Peoples.
2. We call for the establishment of a Permanent International Tribunal for Indigenous Peoples, composed of Indigenous leaders. The institutional mandate of said Tribunal shall be to legally examine the consequences of the application of the Doctrine of Discovery upon Indigenous Peoples. Its composition, as well as its organizational and institutional functioning, shall be determined during a Special Session convened by Indigenous Peoples in October 2026.
3. We, the participants of the International Summit on the Doctrine of Discovery, have decided to demand that the Vatican, the State of Spain, King Felipe VI, and the Government of Mexico establish a Commission for the Historical Clarification – with a scope encompassing the Latin American and Caribbean hemisphere – to review the application of the Doctrine of Discovery.
4. In light of the commitment demonstrated by the Government of Mexico over the last decade toward the history, culture, and rights of Indigenous Peoples, we demand the establishment of a National Commission for the Historical Clarification of Facts regarding the Doctrine of Discovery and its consequences for the Indigenous Peoples of Mexico.

5. We urge the Government of Mexico – as well as all the governments throughout Latin America and the Caribbean – to adopt legislative and administrative measures, at both the national and municipal levels, aimed at removing all figures represented in statues and other symbols that perpetuate and display colonialism, as well as those who committed crimes of genocide, enslavement, and torture – such as Christopher Columbus, Hernán Cortés, Francisco Pizarro, and Pedro de Valdivia, among others.
6. To request that the General Assembly of the Organization of American States (OAS) establish a Working Group for Historical Clarification regarding the Application of the Doctrine of Discovery, and that reparatory measures be established to build a Firm and Lasting Peace in the Hemisphere.
7. To request a formal Hearing with the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR) to demand the application of Article 28 of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples.
8. To attend the Ibero-American Summit of Heads of State and Government, to be held on November 4th and 5th in Madrid, Spain.
9. To appear before the European Court and the International Court of Justice (ICJ) to file formal complaints regarding Crimes Against Humanity committed by the Vatican, the Spanish Monarchy, Spain, and Portugal – among others – due to their responsibility concerning the Doctrine of Discovery.
10. At the International Summit on the Doctrine of Discovery, we have agreed to establish a Continental Coordination body named the “Continental Coordination on the Doctrine of Discovery”, composed of Indigenous Peoples’ leaders; on an interim basis, these leaders are:

Margarita Gutiérrez Romero

COEMI VINAJEL, Pueblo Ñhahñu

Pascual de Jesús Gonzales

MULT, MPCOI, Pueblo Triqui

Haydee Girón Sánchez

TECHANTIT Cultural Center, Pueblo Nahuat-Pipil

Eve Reyes Aguirre

TONATIERRA, Embassy of Indigenous Peoples

Pueblo Izkaloteka

Aucan Huilcaman Paillama

Council of All Lands, Pueblo Mapuche

